



POPULAR PIPER

A Piper Cherokee flies over the desert in California. The Cherokee series, the first of which appeared in 1960, is typical of Piper's successful light aircraft in its reliability, simplicity, and adaptability to different roles.

involved “definitely less risk” than driving, deaths in Flying Flea accidents soon mounted and it was banned by the French government.

Light aircraft

Although there will no doubt always be a self-assembly market for hobbyists, in the end the major genre in private flying became the mass-produced light aircraft. This had to be easy to fly, economical to operate, and robustly reliable, but at the same time offer enough speed and maneuverability to satisfy the leisure flier's aspiration to excitement and fulfill a wide variety of practical functions. State-sponsored flying clubs proliferated in the 1920s in Germany and Britain, where the de Havilland Moth of 1925 quickly established itself as a much-loved favorite. In the United States, the three companies that were to dominate light aircraft manufacture, Cessna, Beech, and Piper, were founded between 1927 and 1937, in the trough of the Great Depression. The early Cessna A, marketed as “everyman's airplane,” proved to be something that everyman, under the economic circumstances of the day, could not afford. But Piper had enormous success with the

FLIGHT ACROSS THE CURTAIN

ONE OF THE MOST FAMOUS flights in a light aircraft was made by Matthias Rust, a 19-year-old German with about 50 hours' flying experience. In May 1987, with the Cold War still in progress, Rust decided to go for a jaunt across the Iron Curtain. Flying solo in a four-seater Cessna, he took off from Helsinki, Finland, and flew east to Moscow, totally eluding the supposedly imposing Soviet air-defense system – apparently, the aircraft was simply too slow to register. Rust cheerfully buzzed the Kremlin before landing alongside Lenin's Mausoleum in Red Square. He emerged from his aircraft to sign autographs for bemused Russian passersby before being put under arrest. His exploit led to the resignation of the Soviet minister of defense and made a small but real contribution to undermining confidence in the communist system before the fall of the Berlin Wall.

RUST IN RED SQUARE

German student Matthias Rust's Cessna sits in Red Square, Moscow, after flying from Finland through Soviet air defenses. The flight made him a hero to many amateur pilots.



Cub. Very stripped down and economical – it had no airspeed indicator or compass – the Piper Cub superseded such veterans of the barnstorming era as the Curtiss Jenny to become the best-selling light aircraft in the United States in the 1930s.

Cessna and Beech, with other manufacturers, profited in the 1950s when the American private

flying market expanded dramatically. One of the most popular aircraft was the appropriately named Beechcraft Bonanza. Cessna's successes included the ubiquitous Cessna 172 of 1955. But Piper long headed the field in quantity production – when the company rolled out its 100,000th machine in 1977, it was estimated to have manufactured one-tenth of all the aircraft ever built in the world. Piper Cherokees and Comanches became so common around busy airports that commercial pilots dubbed their low-altitude airspace “Indian territory.”



FLYING FLEA

Henri Mignet's Pou du Ciel – accurately translated as the Sky Louse, but generally known as the Flying Flea – enjoyed short-lived popularity in the 1930s. Mignet was an eloquent propagandist for private flying, publishing a best-selling book, L'Aviation de l'Amateur, in 1934.